

LFB HOLDINGS

Decision Distortion Assessment Reports

BASE REPORT

Your Decision Distortion Assessment — Bias Is Your Dominant Force

Your assessment is in. Of the four forces that bend organizational judgment under pressure, bias is showing up most actively in your company right now.

Of the four forces — noise, bias, accumulation, and incentive misalignment — bias is the one that moves in a single direction. Noise scatters conclusions randomly; accumulation builds through the weight of individually-defensible decisions; incentives govern the rate at which either compounds. Bias does something different: it systematically bends judgment toward a predictable conclusion before the evidence has had a real chance to land. That consistency is what makes it compound rather than cancel — and what makes it nearly invisible from inside the organization experiencing it.

What bias is

Bias is systematic directional error: judgment pushed consistently in a predictable direction regardless of the evidence. It operates through a mechanism Kahneman calls WYSIATI — What You See Is All There Is. The fast cognitive system constructs coherent, confident narratives from whatever information is available without registering what's absent. The resulting confidence feels warranted because the narrative is internally consistent — not because the underlying judgment is accurate.

Four forms show up most in venture-backed companies. Overconfidence — systematically underestimating implementation complexity, competitive response, and time to revenue. Confirmation bias — weighting evidence that supports the current thesis and discounting evidence that doesn't, often without awareness that the filtering is happening. The planning fallacy — building timelines and resource plans from the inside out, ignoring the base rate of what typically happens to companies at this stage. And escalation of commitment — continuing in a direction past the point where the evidence supports it, because stopping means realizing the original call was wrong.

What these forms share: they don't look like errors from inside. They look like clear thinking, conviction, and pattern recognition.

How it typically shows up

A Series B company raised on a strong enterprise thesis. Early pilots look promising. Six months in, renewal conversations come back soft — not bad, not good, but not what the model assumed. The team reads the softness as implementation friction, as a sales motion problem, as a product gap that can be closed. Each explanation is plausible. Each explanation directs resources toward fixing the thesis rather than questioning it. Twelve months later the renewal data is unambiguous. But the company has built an enterprise sales team, a customer success function, and a product roadmap all oriented around a thesis the market has been declining to confirm since month six.

Overconfidence set the original projections. Confirmation bias filtered the early signals. Escalation of commitment kept the machine running after the signals cleared. None of it looked like bias at the time. It looked like execution.

Where your assessment is pointing most clearly within bias is on anchoring — specifically, the degree to which the first voice in the room becomes everyone else's reference point. The question your assessment flagged is whether your organization manages conversation sequence deliberately or lets it default to seniority and confidence, which amounts to the same thing. The anchor effect is structural, not personal: it operates regardless of whether the first speaker intends to dominate and regardless of whether subsequent speakers are aware of being influenced. In a room where the senior voice goes first, junior and mid-level assessments will systematically cluster around that initial position — not because of deference alone but because of how the human evaluative system works when it has an existing reference point. The correction is also structural: written independent assessments before verbal discussion begins, and a deliberate inversion of the default speaking order. Neither requires changing the culture. Both require changing the meeting format.

Where to start

The first intervention is written independent assessments before any verbal discussion begins. Before the meeting opens, each person records their position in writing — their read of the situation, their conclusion, and the reasoning behind it. These are collected before anyone speaks. The anchor effect requires a reference point to operate; removing the first spoken opinion from the room removes the anchor before it can set. This is the single highest-leverage structural change available for anchor-driven bias and it requires no cultural shift — only a change in meeting format.

The second is a deliberate inversion of the default speaking order. When the written assessments have been collected and the discussion opens, the most senior person in the room goes last, not first. This isn't about deference or hierarchy — it's about preventing the most influential voice from collapsing the range of available positions before the room has heard them. Junior and mid-level assessments carry information the senior read may not have. That information is only accessible if it arrives before the anchor sets, not after.

The research behind this

The academic foundation for what your assessment detected comes primarily from *Thinking, Fast and Slow* by Daniel Kahneman — the foundational account of how the fast cognitive system generates systematic directional errors that the slow, corrective system is too depleted or inattentive to catch. The WYSIATI mechanism, the planning fallacy, confirmation bias, and escalation of commitment are all documented there in detail. The insight that matters most for your situation: bias rarely feels like bias from the inside, because the narrative it produces is internally coherent. Coherence is not accuracy.

What's next

The full Decision Distortion whitepaper from LFB Holdings walks through how bias combines with the other three forces — noise, accumulation, and incentive misalignment — and how to locate the specific points in your decision process where a single closed gap would have the greatest effect.

If you'd like to talk through what your results mean for your company specifically, we're glad to do that.

LFB Holdings: lfbholdings.com

For ongoing case-by-case analysis of how these forces operate in real organizational decisions, Bad Call is a subscription brief that applies this framework to actual decision sequences — company autopsies, one at a time.

Bad Call: badcall.ai